



Guiding force: Sri Lanka captain Chamari Athapaththu speaks to her teammates during a team huddle, her voice still the guiding force of a side learning to balance experience with promise in a changing era for women's cricket. GETTYIMAGES

Between rain and rebuild, Sri Lanka's women search for a second sunrise



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In Colombo's rain-soaked World Cup, Sri Lanka's women's team fights not only opponents but history — balancing veterans, new faces, and a system **still learning to grow.**

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In the early days of the Women's ODI World Cup, on a muggy night in Colombo, Sri Lanka head coach Rumesh Rathnayake looked preoccupied as he oversaw training at the Colombo Cricket Club Ground. A crucial game against

Australia beckoned, and Sri Lanka's flaws with the bat and in the field had been laid bare.

The team's extremes in experience are striking. A 40-year-old Udesika Prabodhani leads the pace attack, 39-year-old Inoka Ranaweera remains its ace spinner, 35-year-old Anushka

Sanjeewani has been among the best keepers in the tournament, and the side continues to rely on 35-year-old Chamari Athapaththu for both performance and inspiration. At the other end are 20-year-olds like Vishmi Gunaratne and Dewmi Vihanga, still finding their footing on a stage that